Ruoqing Yao

ryao10@ucsc.edu Linkedin Personal website

Last updated: 2026-10-12

Education

2023 - **Ph.D. student** in Linguistics, University of California, Santa Cruz
Advisor: Matt Wagers

2019 - 2023 **B.S.** (*summa cum laude*) in Computer Science and Linguistics (double major), with Departmental Honors in Linguistics, William & Mary
Thesis: *Referential resolution for resumptive pronouns in island-violating sentences*
Advisor: Anya Hogoboom

2025 The Ninth Summer School on Statistical Methods for Linguistics and Psychology (SMLP), University of Potsdam

2022 Stanford CSLI Summer Internship Program, Stanford University
Advisor: Judith Degen, Jiayi Lu

2020 Semester exchange program, Beijing Normal University

Research Interests

Sentence processing, Computational linguistics, Dependency parsing, Psycholinguistics, Mechanistic interpretability, Experimental syntax

Publications

2026 **Yao, R.**, Anand, P. (2026). Probing the Attention Representation of Filler-Gap Dependency in Transformers. In Proceedings of the Society for Computation in Linguistics 2026 (pp. 258-261).

2025 **Yao, R.**, Wagers, M. (2025). Who and when gets the race? Two processing routes for the advantages and penalties of pronominal ambiguity resolution. In Proceedings of the Annual Meeting of the Cognitive Science Society (Vol. 47).

Presentations

Oral Presentations

2026 **Yao, R.**, Anand, P. Probing the Attention Representation of Filler-Gap Dependency in Transformers. Society of Computation in Linguistics, Workshop at The 64th Annual Meeting of the Association for Computational Linguistics. San Diego, CA. July 3-4, 2026.

Kogan, M., Borra, A., **Yao, R.**, Wagers, M. Syntactic positional similarity modulates interference for thematic and agreement dependencies. Long Talk at the Conference on Human Sentence Processing (HSP) 39, MIT. March 26-28, 2026.

2025 Kogan, M.*, **Yao, R.*** Modeling interference with distributed representations of lexical, morphological, and positional information. 2025 Fall Meeting of the Bay

Area Language Processing Interest Group (BAyLI). University of California, Santa Cruz, CA. October 10.

2024 **Yao, R.**, Lu, J., Degen, J. Perceived interpretability predicts satiability for CNPC islands but not WH islands. California Meeting on Psycholinguistics[6]. Stanford University, Stanford, CA. January 14.

Yao, R., Hogoboom, A. Resumptive Pronouns in Islands Show Confusability Advantage Effect. 2024 Linguistics Society of America Annual Meeting. New York City, NY. January 7.

2023 **Yao, R**. The Processing of Resumptive Pronouns in Islands. Graduate and Honors Research Symposium. William & Mary, Williamsburg, VA. March 30.

Posters

2026 **Yao, R.**, Anand, P., France, A., Hauseman, H., Wagers, M., Reynaga, J. Analyzing the quality of LLM-assisted summary writing. Poster at the 67th Psychonomics Society Annual Meeting. San Diego, CA. November 19-22.

Reynaga, J., Anand, P., France, A., Hauseman, H., Wagers, M., **Yao, R.** LLM-Assisted Writing and Students' Perceptions of AI Support. Poster at the 67th Psychonomics Society Annual Meeting. San Diego, CA. November 19-22.

2025 Kogan, M.*, **Yao, R.***, Wagers, M. Sources of distortion and confusion in distributed representations of morphosyntactic structure. Poster at the California Meeting on Psycholinguistics (CAMP) 8. University of California, Davis. November 14-16.

Yao, R., Wagers, M. Who and when gets the race? Two processing routes for the advantages and penalties of pronominal ambiguity resolution. Poster at The 47th Annual Meeting of the Cognitive Science Society, San Francisco, CA. July 30-August 2.

Yao, R., Wagers, M. Who Gets to Race? The Effect of Initial Bias on Pronominal Ambiguity Advantage. Poster at the 38th Annual Conference on Human Sentence Processing. University of Maryland, College Park, MD. March 27-29.

2022 Parker, D., Glauser, C., Rust, G., Wright, N., **Yao, R.**, Antecedent reactivation leads to faster retrieval: Evidence from ellipsis. Poster at the 35th Annual Conference on Human Sentence Processing. University of California, Santa Cruz, CA. March 24.

Yao, R, Satiability and Interpretability. Poster at the W&M 2022 Fall Undergraduate Research Symposium. William & Mary, Williamsburg, VA . September 30.

Research Positions

At UC Santa Cruz

2025 Graduate Research Assistant, THINK at UCSC: Technology + Humanities Integrated Knowledge (NEH AC-303525-25)
PI: Benjamin Breen; Co-PIs: Pranav Anand, Zac Zimmer

2024 - Graduate Research Assistant, Writing With ChatGPT: The Learning Promises and Perils of Co-Writing with Generative Models in College Linguistics Classes (sponsored by the Spencer Foundation)
PI: Pranav Anand; Co-PIs: Matt Wagers, Hannah Hausman

At Stanford

2022 Research Intern, InterActive Language Processing Lab at Stanford (ALPS)
Supervisor: Judith Degen, Jiayi Lu

At William & Mary

2021 - 2022 Research Assistant, The Cognitive Basis of Linguistic Illusions (NSF-BCS1843309), Computational and Experimental Linguistics Lab (CELL)
PI: Dan Parker

2021 - 2022 Research Assistant, LabPhon Lab
PI: Anya Hogoboom

Teaching Experience

At UC Santa Cruz

2026 Associate Instructor, F26 NLP 270 Linguistic methods of syntax and semantics for computer scientists
Teaching Assistant, S26 LING171 Psycholinguistics I
Teaching Assistant, W26 LING172 Psycholinguistics II

2025 Teaching Assistant, S25 LING50 Introduction to Linguistics

2024 Teaching Assistant, F24 LING171 Psycholinguistics I
Reader, S24 LING50 Introduction to Linguistics

At William & Mary

2022 Grader, MATH 211 Linear Algebra

Academic Service

2024 - 2025 Coordinator, Speech and Sentence Processing Lab (s/lab), UCSC

2024 Spring Co-coordinator, Speech and Sentence Processing Lab (s/lab), UCSC

2024 - Reviewer, CogSci 2024, 2025, 2026

2023 - Reviewer, California Meeting on Psycholinguistics[6, 7, 8]

Work and Mentor Experience

2024 - 2025 Mentor, GradPath UCSC

2021 Linguistics specialist intern, NetEase Youdao Co. Ltd

2020 - 2022 Peer advisor, William & Mary Academic Advising

2019-2020 Research assistant, William & Mary Global Research Institute

Leadership Experience

2025 - 2026 Captain, UCSC Table Tennis Club

2021 - 2023 President, William & Mary Club Table Tennis

Awards and Honors

2026 Summer Professional Development Fund ($500), UC Santa Cruz

2024 Graduate Dean's Research Travel Grant ($300), UC Santa Cruz

2023 Phi Beta Kappa, William & Mary

2019-2023 Dean's List (for all semesters enrolled), William & Mary

2021 Ranked (Top 20%), 2020 ICPC Mid-Atlantic North America Regional Programming Contest

Skills

Languages | Mandarin Chinese (Native); English (Proficient); French (research ability); Korean (research ability); Japanese (research ability)

Programming Languages | Python; R; Java; JavaScript; HTML; SQL; C++

Software and Tools | Ibex; LaTeX; Prolific & Proliferate; Praat